

Reforming Research Assessment at the University of South Bohemia in České Budějovice

CoARA¹ Action Plan 2024 – 2028

September 2024

Introduction

The University of South Bohemia in České Budějovice (also referred to as “USB”) signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment² (also referred to as “ARRA”) in June 2023. The main reason for making this critical step is our valuation of a positive research culture that recognises and rewards quality in all its aspects, promotes research integrity, and supports the career development of all staff involved in research, the assets that we also highlight in our recently issued USB Research Strategy. Acknowledging the ten below-listed CoARA commitments we have signed up to and respecting field-specific needs and expectations, we are ready to review and revise our current research assessment policies following just these commitments:

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to and careers in research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment.
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to.
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes.
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments.
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research.

The basic framework for the evaluation of research in Czechia is the Methodology for the Evaluation of Research Organisations and the Evaluation of Programmes of Special Purpose Support for Research, Development, and Innovation (also referred to as “Methodology”), whose creator and guarantor is the Research, Development and Innovation Council of the Government of the Czech Republic. For universities, the aim of this evaluation is twofold: give universities feedback on their past efforts as well as recommendations for their further development and international competitiveness, with high-quality European universities serving as benchmarks, and provide the

¹ Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment, <https://coara.eu/>

² <https://coara.eu/agreement/the-agreement-full-text/>

Ministry of Education, Youth, and Sports of the Czech Republic (also referred to as “MEYS”) a tool for decision-making on the provision of institutional support for research, development, and innovation.

This evaluation is carried out in five separate modules³:

- M1 - Quality of Selected Results (evaluation of selected results in two categories: contribution to knowledge and social relevance),
- M2 - Research Performance (overall research performance based mainly on bibliographic data),
- M3 - Social Relevance (impact of research on society, in particular applied research),
- M4 - Viability (quality of management and internal processes of research organisations),
- M5 - Strategy and Policies (research strategy of research organisations).

The annual evaluation of research organisations under the Methodology is carried out in modules M1 and M2, whereas a complete assessment in all five modules is carried out in five-year cycles. The evaluation in modules M3-M5 is conducted at the provider level (MEYS) through the International Evaluation Panel (IEP) set up for each university, with module M3 being evaluated at the level of faculties or other relevant units and modules M4 and M5 at the level of the university. According to the Methodology, the first comprehensive evaluation occurred in 2020; the next is planned for 2025.

USB applies several levels of internal evaluation of research. At the university level, USB has its research assessment methodology, serving to stimulate regular discussions with the faculty management on the direction and strategy of research at individual faculties, as well as having a direct impact on faculty budgets, providing the USB management a tool for decision-making on the provision of institutional support for research, development, and innovation across faculties. This methodology was established a few years ago, among others, to be resilient to possible abrupt annual changes in research performance and, hence, individual faculty research budgets. In particular, a set of performance indicators is used for funding, but they have only partial weight in the actual research budget.

In general, this evaluation includes both overall research performance based on bibliographic indicators and evaluation of selected research results in the form of peer review, thus, to an extent, mirroring the M1 and M2 modules of the national Methodology. But it reflects other creative or research-related activities of USB researchers, too (artistic activities, patents, success in external project funding, publications in conference proceedings), thus acknowledging a broader range of research outputs beyond mere publication results (admitting that research articles remain and will form the central research output).

Finally, researchers at all USB faculties are assessed based on a formalized questionnaire within the information system EAS (Evaluation of Academic Staff) developed at the Palacký University of Olomouc, Czechia. This system enables the results of educational and research activities of individual researchers to be monitored and aggregated at any management level. The evaluation results are used directly to distribute funding for creative activities within some faculties and identify and reward excellent individuals and research teams. This tool aims not to accept calculated absolute values uncritically but rather to identify weak points within faculties and departments or to monitor long-term trends, and in particular, to respond creatively and managerially to these relative (compared to other units) outputs. The EAS information system is continuously developed and supplemented with

³ <https://www.vyzkum.cz/FrontClanek.aspx?idsekce=799796>

additional functionalities, and great effort is devoted to its interconnection with other university and non-university databases and applications.

Recently, USB has introduced research awards in four disciplinary categories, each divided into a category for the academic staff and for students, for excellent results of research activities, including scientific publications or results of applied research. Student prizes can also be awarded for excellent bachelor's, master's, or doctoral theses. The subject categories and respective prizes are as follows:

- Natural sciences – Zdeněk Veselovský Prize in honour of one of the most important Czech zoologists, who, among other things, worked at the present-day Faculty of Natural Sciences of the SBU,
- Agricultural and Fishery Sciences – Jakub Krčín Award in honour of the Regent of Rožmberk and one of the most famous Czech fish farmers,
- Social Sciences – Jiří František August Buquoy Award in honour of the Austrian and Czech economist, scientist, writer, entrepreneur and inventor,
- Humanities – Robert Sak Award in honour of an important Czech historian who, among others, worked at the Faculties of Education and Arts of USB.

Also, USB has introduced the Jana Anna Kateřina Zátková Award for an excellent popularization work of a monographic nature that brings a selected field of science closer to a broader readership or for a series of popularizing articles, media appearances, or popularizing lectures that promote science in general or its specific field. The award is named in honour of an important union official and fighter for women's rights, co-founder and long-term chairperson of the České Budějovice Women's Association Ludmila, who supported women's education, among others.

Individual USB faculties also have their specific recruitment and career development (promotion) assessment practices, which also largely involve assessing research performance. Moreover, faculties are internally evaluated in five-year cycles based on self-evaluation reports and onsite visits by internal evaluation committees. This evaluation, also comprising the faculty's research output and outreach, provides critical feedback for further faculty development, following its mission and in all its important aspects.

Inseparable from the inevitable task of research assessment is an obligation from both the university and the individual faculties to create and maintain a positive research culture, starting from low-level conditions as clean, sufficiently spacious and suitably equipped research environment, through incentives for development and evolution of both individual researchers and whole research groups, up to transparent and stimulating institutional research policies, such as USB Research Code of Practice, USB Code of Ethics, USB Gender Equality Plan, or USB (and faculty) Career Development Plan. USB is also a proud recipient of the "HR Excellence in Research Award" (shortly HR Award) for excellence in caring for human resources in a scientific environment. For researchers, an organization with the HR Award guarantees the European standard of employee care, the openness and transparency of the selection process, and the quality of the working environment. The HR Award logo means greater attractiveness for the organization when approaching researchers from abroad or obtaining grants.

At all levels of research assessment (and likewise at the national level), the USB policies are, in many aspects, already in line with several CoARA commitments. On the other hand, we sense changes in the European research environment and feel obliged to do more in this respect. For example, we currently work hard on AI and Open Science policies and strive to raise awareness in these domains, especially regarding good research practices. USB is thus committed to further development in this

area and signed ARRA for this reason. This demonstrates USB's dedication to making tangible improvements to research assessment and, more broadly, to research culture, which aligns with our vision, mission, and values. We aim not only to become more transparent and just concerning our academic personnel but also strive to regain and reinforce trust in research in general, lost mainly during the COVID-19 pandemic times. The latter might be accomplished by showing concern for humanity and the environment, discussions with, education of, and sharing information with the public, mainly through honest and socially relevant research and openness of as many doors of our research endeavour as possible.

Our vision for reform

USB has recently issued a USB Research Strategy, a strategic document providing a vision of the character of research on USB. It formulates directions, aims, and values we aim to achieve, pursue, support, and value in research, from the institutional level down to the level of individual academics. Specifically, it provides a framework through which we want to develop our excellence further and, thanks to research of an interdisciplinary and international nature, use this excellence to solve global societal challenges and regional problems and deepen knowledge about the world we share. Therefore, the four focal areas of the USB Research Strategy are:

- Development and support of research excellence
- Transgressing boundaries of (not only) research fields
- Societal relevance of science and research
- Development of international dimension

USB thus strives to create an exceptional, values-led research environment where colleagues feel deeply connected with our research strategy and have the skills, motivation, and reward for delivering it. The same holds for USB management, given that many strategic aims involve establishing and implementing adequate policies, processes, and top-down motivational tools. To achieve this, it is pivotal that research assessment processes align with the USB's values and recognise and reward the diverse range of contributions to the research endeavour. Moreover, research assessment processes must accurately and appropriately assess what they set out to do without creating incentives for behaviours contrary to our values and goals. USB will deliver a coordinated approach to embedding responsible research assessment practices across the institution, supporting sustainable and diversified research quality, strengthening the research culture, and promoting research integrity. That said, on our way to implementing the USB Research Strategy, we aim to account for all ten CoARA commitments and use the opportunity to review and possibly revise our institutional and individual research assessment procedures outlined above. All these pieces should reflect each other and compose a coherent, perfectly fitted working environment in which conducting research is a mission, pride, commitment to society, and joy.

Recognising the multi-faceted nature of research assessment (e.g., a wide range of possible research outputs, diversity of research fields at USB, variety of career lengths of individual researchers), our reform leading to the responsible research assessment will be mediated and overseen by a dedicated working group with representatives from the academic staff as well as those responsible for delivery of research assessment processes. This working group will agree on the core principles of responsible research assessment to be promoted across the institution, implement necessary changes to research assessment processes, and compile and publish a policy on responsible research assessment to bring together relevant policies and guidance and promote transparency in research assessment. Training

and further refinement will follow to develop greater comprehension, acceptance, literacy, and competencies in responsible research assessment across the institution, potentially leading to higher excellence and competitiveness of the research conducted at USB.

Changes at the central level do not necessarily mirror themselves at the level of smaller units such as departments or research teams. We are also fully aware that reform can only be achieved when there is a change at lower levels. Therefore, in implementing the reform, we will also pursue the following key objectives:

- make the eventual USB Policy on Responsible Research Assessment simple yet comprehensive, transparent, and openly available,
- disseminate sense and meaning of the policy, allow for broad discussion, and adopt refinements, when necessary,
- respect field-specific expectations (but avoid within-field inbreeding and ensuing fitness decline),

and account for all four core areas of research work:

- research (publication outputs),
- teaching and supervision (research-based and research-oriented teaching and project and theses leading, the latter based on the current supervisor's research interests),
- community engagement and societal outreach (applied and contractual research, knowledge and technology transfer, popularisation, and policy-making activities),
- teamwork, management, and/or leadership (leading projects, engaging in various research boards, organising scientific meetings, sticking to and spreading research ethics).

Action Plan

Reform, whatever its extent, is rarely a swift action. Instead, it is a thoughtful and carefully planned endeavour that needs to involve all relevant players, from individual researchers from all represented fields to the top university management, intending to seek and direct to a well-defined, common goal, which here is an implementation of the ten CoARA commitments and formulation and publication of the USB Policy on Responsible Research Assessment.

Here, we define the actions needed to achieve this and their connections to the above-mentioned CoARA commitments. Inspired by an already published CoARA Action Plan⁴, we divide our path to our goal into the following four phases:

1. Establish and Engage – establish an institutional working group, perform an analysis of current research assessment practices, initiate engagement activities with the research community,
2. Review and Revise – identify priority procedures based on the analysis and design necessary reforms,
3. Implement and Innovate – implement proposed reforms with ongoing monitoring to check that reforms are addressing the CoARA commitments,

⁴ A five-year CoARA action plan by the University of Strathclyde in Glasgow, <https://zenodo.org/records/10017553>

4. Evaluate and Evolve – formally evaluate the success of reforms in addressing the CoARA commitments and the stated objectives of this Action Plan.

USB is committed to undertaking the activity necessary to achieve our objectives by the end of 2029. In line with the need for responsible research assessment to be sensitive to its context and recognise that notions of best practices may change, no fixed timeframe is provided. Still, our goal is that, in general, every task takes up to one year. Progress against actions from the previous year and a detailed action plan for the following year will be presented to the Rector's Advisory Board at the November meeting each year. We will also regularly consult our steps and outcomes nationally with universities that have issued a CoARA Action Plan and monitor global developments within CoARA.

Task 1: Establish and Engage

Relevant CoARA commitments: 6, 7, 10

The first year of the action plan will focus on identifying the challenges and opportunities relating to research assessment reform at USB and building relationships with necessary stakeholders to foster engagement in the future. Therefore, the primary outcomes for this task are the establishment of the institutional working group, the completion of an analysis of current research assessment practices, and initial engagement activities with the research community.

1.1 Establish an institutional working group responsible for the reform.

1.2 Conduct a detailed overview of research assessment practices and processes at USB, from the central level through the faculty and department levels to the level of individual researchers, including the research assessment parts of the recruitment and career development (promotion) criteria.

1.3 Analyse which of these practices and processes meet or do not meet the CoARA commitments, with a particular emphasis (but not only) on the use and impact of bibliometrics, the range of criteria (activities) relevant to the current research assessment, and dealing with responsible publishing and open science activities.

1.4 Identify units and committees at USB that deal with topics related to research assessment and establish their mutual collaboration.

1.5 Compile and publish a summary report on findings, including how current assessment is done at various levels so that individual researchers understand it.

1.6 Organise seminars and discussions on CoARA and related topics (such as bibliometrics, university rankings, responsible publishing, and open science) and publish findings.

Task 2: Review and Revise

Relevant CoARA commitments: 1, 2, 3, 4, 6

This task will identify priority procedures based on the analysis and design necessary reforms. Once the reforms have been designed, guidance and infrastructure required for effective implementation need to be established. The working group will communicate their activities internally and externally to promote transparency and share good practices.

2.1 Based on the analysis and identified practices and processes that do not comply with the CoARA commitments, formulate policies that will eventually meet them. This may include the USB Open Science policy, USB policy on responsible use of AI in research, USB policy on responsible publication and use of metrics, and research assessment processes currently in practice described in the Introduction.

2.2 Analyse how all this fits into the USB Research Strategy, and if necessary, refine the latter.

2.3 In collaboration with faculties, analyse field-specific expectations (including a breadth of the range of plausible and valuable research outputs) and criteria considered relevant to the research assessment, centrally and individually. Avoid within-field inbreeding and ensuing fitness decline. These criteria should value all academic activities in research, teaching and supervision, community engagement and societal outreach, and teamwork, management, and/or leadership. They should also reflect an interdisciplinary and international research character.

2.4 Compile a summary report on all the above subtasks, suggesting what should be done to meet the CoARA commitments.

2.5 Compile a separate policy on responsible publishing and future career expectations for doctoral students (including their supervisors), the most sensitive and formative stage in a research career.

2.6 Consider individuals' and departments' career length, vision, mission, and focus in formulating a responsible research assessment policy.

Task 3: Implement and Innovate

Relevant CoARA commitments: 5, 7, 8, 9

Within this task, proposed reforms will be implemented with ongoing monitoring to ensure that they address our principles, values, and CoARA commitments. This will primarily include adherence to the USB Research Strategy. Guidance and criteria relevant to the reformed procedures will be available under the USB Policy on Responsible Research Assessment to promote transparency and engagement with reforms. The working group will continue to engage with the research community and communicate activities internally and externally.

3.1 Allocate resources for pursuing the reform. Identify what guidance and infrastructure we need to implement the CoARA commitments.

3.2 Share experiences with the reform with stakeholders and national and European universities, including those already having a CoARA Action Plan.

3.3 Communicate the resulting policies, processes, and motivational and research funding schemes simply and transparently to a broad academic community at USB via many channels and a dedicated web page.

3.4 Prepare case studies in various fields on how to assess research excellence.

Task 4: Evaluate and Evolve

Relevant CoARA commitments: 6, 7, 8, 9, 10

Within this final task, a formal evaluation will be conducted to assess the success of reforms in addressing the CoARA commitments and the stated objectives of this action plan. This will include gathering feedback from those involved in reformed procedures (including those who run the procedures and those they apply to) to understand varied perspectives on whether reforms were appropriate and beneficial. Outcomes from these evaluations will be used to make further adjustments and refinements. Internal and external communication will promote transparency and engagement.

5.1 Evaluate the success of reforms in addressing the ARRA commitments and the stated objectives of this Action Plan. Make any necessary adjustments and refinements.

5.2 Compile and publish USB Policy on Responsible Research Assessment as a summary report. Train academic staff and students on good research practices (incl. professionalism, integrity, ethical considerations, bias avoidance).

5.3 Compile and publish USB Policy on Good Practice in Scientific Publishing (including how we work with bibliometrics).

5.4 Monitor and regularly report on the progress of implementation of the CoARA commitments and produce and publish a comprehensive, final 5-year evaluation report.

5.5 Report regularly on the progress of implementation of CoARA commitments at relevant fora.